



Marie-Louise's diadem

△ Marie-Louise's diadem, reset with turquoise cabochons

Few pieces of historic jewellery have undergone such a dramatic makeover as the Marie-Louise Diadem. Dating from 1810, the tiara was originally studded with 79 deep green Colombian emeralds totalling 700 carats. It is named after Empress Marie-Louise of France, who received the headpiece from her husband Napoleon I to mark their wedding in 1810. Made in Paris by Francois-Regnault Nitot of Etienne Nitot et Fils (which later became the jeweller Chaumet), it was part of an emerald and diamond parure that included a necklace, comb, belt buckle, and earrings.

When Napoleon's empire crumbled, Marie-Louise fled to Austria and, on her death, left the parure to her aunt, Archduchess Elise. However, in the 1950s, jewellery maker Van Cleef & Arpels acquired the diadem from a descendent of Elise, and removed and sold the emeralds at auction.



Replica of the parure's emerald necklace

The company advertised them with the catchphrase, "An emerald for you from the historic Napoleonic Tiara..." The gems consisted of a central emerald weighing 12 carats, along with 21 other large emeralds and 57 smaller ones.

Van Cleef & Arpels replaced the emeralds with 79 turquoise cabochons, a change that horrified some, but appealed to others. One such admirer was American socialite and breakfast cereal heiress Marjorie Merriweather Post. She purchased the tiara in 1971, adding it to her extraordinary collection of jewellery, which had included a 263-carat diamond necklace commissioned by Napoleon as a gift for Marie-Louise when she gave birth to their son in 1811 (see pp.284–85). After wearing the reworked turquoise diadem a few times, Merriweather Post donated it to the American Smithsonian Institution, where it can still be seen today.

A turquoise given by a loving hand carries with it happiness and good fortune

Arabic proverb

Key dates

1810–1971

